

RUSSIAN TEA CULTURE

Traditionally brewed using water heated in a samovar, tea has been enjoyed in Russia since the 17th century, when it was brought to the country from China. Today, tea is so popular in Russia that it is considered the national beverage.

Tea was first introduced to Russia in 1638, when it was gifted to Tsar Mikhail I by the Mongolians. A few decades later, the Russians sampled tea from China, and in 1679, signed a treaty with the Chinese for a regular supply of tea in exchange for animal furs.

By the 1870s, both loose black and brick tea were being imported from China, and tea had become inextricably linked with the Russian way of life. Marriages were arranged, business deals sealed, and differences resolved over a cup of tea.

Tea was prepared using water heated in a self-heating boiler called a samovar. A dense tea concentrate, or “zavarka,” which had a tea-to-water ratio of 5 teaspoons of loose black tea per cup, was brewed in a teapot, or “chainik.” The chainik was placed on top of the samovar to warm.

The lady of the house would pour the zavarka into glass cups and add additional hot water from the samovar, diluting the strength to suit the guest’s taste. Tea was usually taken black, or with lemon, and sweetened with jam, honey, or sugar. It was accompanied by snacks, such as “syrniki,” which are thick cheese pancakes served with jam, and small biscuits known as Russian tea cakes, made with ground nuts, butter, and flour, and

rolled in confectioners’ sugar. Traditionally, the hot tea glasses were placed in metal holders, or “podstakannik,” which allowed the drinker to sip the hot tea without burning their fingers.

In modern Russia, tea is still served at most social occasions, with loose tea being far more popular than the tea bag. Although the traditional samovar is now rarely used in everyday life, it remains a powerful symbol of Russian society, invoking positive feelings of warmth, comfort, and togetherness.



SAMOVAR

Originally utilitarian in design, samovars came to be highly decorative pieces of art.

